Parshas Ki Teitzei

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# the Lamplighter

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## Parsha Insights

## Vinegar for the Soul

By Chaya Shuchat

Memory is a terrible thing to lose, a fact that becomes painfully clear when you reach middle age. But forgetting can have its uses as well. For one thing, it keeps the mind from being cluttered with irrelevant information. And memory loss can even be therapeutic—such as when we overlook past hurts and agree to forgive and forget. For survivors of trauma, the ability to let go of frightful memories is essential to the healing process.

One of the most traumatic events in early Jewish history was the ambush of Amalek on the newly liberated people, fresh out of Egypt. Amalek was the first nation that dared attack the Jews after G-d miraculously redeemed them, and in their vulnerable state, this attack was particularly devastating. In this week's Torah portion, we find a curious mitzvah: Remember to forget Amalek.



"You shall remember what Amalek did to you on the way, when you went out of Egypt . . . You shall obliterate the remembrance of Amalek from beneath the heavens. Do not forget!"

This mitzvah is one of the "Six Remembrances," events recorded in the Torah that we are commanded to remember every day, including the exodus from Egypt, the giving of the Torah on Mount Sinai, and the Shabbat day of rest.

If you are wondering how remembering an attack by Amalek fits in with remembering sanctified occasions such as the Shabbat and the exodus from Egypt, you're not alone. The Midrash writes that after the commandment to remember Amalek was given, the Jews said to Moses: "One Scripture text says, 'Remember the Sabbath day, to keep it holy,' and it is written, 'Remember what Amalek did unto you.' How can both these texts be fulfilled?"

The question the Jews were asking was: how can we keep such opposite thoughts in mind at the same time? Sanctifying the Shabbat helps to implant in our heart the awareness that G-d is the Creator of all existence. Amalek, in contrast, is a nation that "knows its Creator and deliberately rebels against Him." How can we remember the holiness of Shabbat at the same time that we call to mind the evil of Amalek?

And to this, Moses answered, "The glass of spiced wine is not to be compared to the glass of vinegar! One 'Remember' is in order to observe and to sanctify the Sabbath day, and the other 'Remember' is in order to destroy."

Why does Moses compare the memory of Amalek to a glass of vinegar?

Vinegar on its own is excessively sour and not fit to drink. Mixed with other foods, however, it adds flavoring, and even has health benefits. Furthermore, since vinegar is derived from wine, it has some of the properties of the wine itself.

What this means in spiritual terms is that even an experience as sour as our encounter with Amalek has a source in holiness. In fact, the very existence of an entity that "knows its Creator and intentionally rebels against Him" is a testimony to G-d's omnipotence. G-d created a world with dueling, conflicting powers to give us the opportunity to vanquish the evil and channel its energy to good.

This is why Moses compared both the Shabbat and Amalek to a glass. Both are vessels for containing G-dly energy. However, the vessel of Shabbat, the "glass of spiced wine," requires no special preparation. It is ready to drink as is. The cup of Amalek, on the other hand, is not a suitable container for G-dliness until it undergoes some refinement—its tendency to rebel must be tempered and channeled appropriately. Then it, too, is a vessel for G-dliness, with life-sustaining power of its own.

In the Tanya, Rabbi Schneur Zalman of Liadi describes two types of delicacies: those that are sweet, and those that are sharp or sour, but

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### What is a Lamplighter?

Every Jew is charged with the mission of brightening the world around him.

Just as the old-time lamppost was lit using a long torch held by the lamplighter, so too in our modern realm of darkness, it is our job to be the lamplighter and bring the light of Torah to those around us.

The lamplighters' obligation is not restricted to any specific terrain or conditions; rather he must be prepared to leap even into the deepest seas in order to transmit it's glow to those drowning in the waters of assimilation.

### Candle Lighting Times

Greater Toronto Area

| | |
|---|---|
| Light Candles | 7:53 PM |
| Shabbos Ends | 8:55 PM |

Parsha in a Nutshell

# Parshas Ki Teitzei

The name of the Parshah, "Ki Teitzei," means "when you go out," and it is found in Deuteronomy 21:10.

Seventy-four of the Torah's 613 commandments (mitzvot) are in the Parshah of Ki Teitzei. These include the laws of the beautiful captive, the inheritance rights of the firstborn, the wayward and rebellious son, burial and dignity of the dead, returning a lost object, sending away the mother bird before taking her young, the duty to erect a safety fence around the roof of one's home, and the various forms of kilayim (forbidden plant and animal hybrids).

Also recounted are the judicial procedures and penalties for adultery, for the rape or seduction of an unmarried girl, and for a husband who falsely accuses his wife of infidelity. The following cannot marry a person of Jewish lineage: a mamzer (someone born from an adulterous or incestuous relationship); a male of Moabite or Ammonite descent; a first- or second-generation Edomite or Egyptian.

Our Parshah also includes laws governing the purity of the military camp; the prohibition against turning in an escaped slave; the duty to pay a worker on time, and to allow anyone working for you—man or animal—to "eat on the job"; the proper treatment of a debtor, and the prohibition against charging interest on a loan; the laws of divorce (from which are also derived many of the laws of marriage); the penalty of thirty-nine lashes for transgression of a Torah prohibition; and the procedures for yibbum ("levirate marriage") of the wife of a deceased childless brother, or chalitzah ("removing of the shoe") in the case that the brother-in-law does not wish to marry her.

Ki Teitzei concludes with the obligation to remember "what Amalek did to you on the road, on your way out of Egypt."

## Food For Thought

*Getting to where you need to be is an important step.*
*But nothing is as important as getting out of where you're at right now.*

Your thoughts on the Lamplighter matter!
Tell us what you like and how we can improve it.

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when properly prepared can be tasty condiments. As it is written in Proverbs, "The L-rd made everything for His praise—even the wicked man for the day of evil." When the evil man repents for his evil and returns to G-d, then the energy that he put into his wickedness becomes converted into holiness—the darkness of his past deeds becomes a greater light.

And this is how we can remember Shabbat and Amalek in the very same breath. On the one hand, celebrating Shabbat is a time to disconnect from worldliness for a short while. We might think that it would be best to let the memory of Amalek fade into the background for the time being. We want to enjoy our sweet wine with no taint of vinegar. Yet the power of Amalek is so great that it can disturb the tranquility of Shabbat—so even on Shabbat, we must be vigilant and protect ourselves against it.

On the other hand, there are times when we are not in a Shabbat mindset. Perhaps we are in a state when we are completely absorbed in the "Amalek" aspects of our lives—the pain, the turmoil and the trauma. We need no memory of Amalek, since it surrounds us constantly. In this situation, holding on to the memory of Shabbat will help us rise above our circumstances. It will even help us recognize that this period of evil that we are going through is temporary, and it, too, has a source in holiness. Life may have dealt us a glass of vinegar—but we can draw strength from it and turn that glass of vinegar into a life-sustaining brew.

Jewish Matters

## Observances for the Month of Elul

"Though summer still lingered and the day was bright and sunny, there was a change in the air. One smelled already the Elul-scent; a teshuvah-wind was blowing. Everyone grew more serious, more thoughtful... All awaited the call of the shofar, the first blast that would announce the opening of the gates of the month of mercy...." That's how the sixth Lubavitcher Rebbe described the onset of Elul in the town of Lubavitch — a month tinged with awe at the approaching High Holidays, yet softened by themes of divine compassion.

As the last month of the Jewish year, Elul is traditionally a time of introspection and stocktaking — a time to review one's deeds and spiritual progress over the past year and prepare for the upcoming "Days of Awe" of Rosh HaShanah and Yom Kippur.

As the month of Divine Mercy and Forgiveness, it is a most opportune time for teshuvah ("return" to G-d), prayer, charity, and increased Ahavat Yisrael (love for a fellow Jew) in the quest for self-improvement and coming closer to G-d. Chassidic master Rabbi Schneur Zalman of Liadi likens the month of Elul to a time when "the king is in the field" and, in contrast to when he is in the royal palace, "everyone who so desires is permitted to meet him, and he receives them all with a cheerful countenance and shows a smiling face to them all."

Specific Elul customs include the daily sounding of the shofar as a call to repentance. Each weekday morning, the shofar sounds as a call to repentance, urging increased study, prayer, and charity. The Chasidic Master, the Baal Shem Tov instituted the custom of reciting three additional chapters of Psalms each day, from the 1st of Elul until Yom Kippur.

Elul is also the recommended time to have one's tefillin and mezuzahs checked by an accredited scribe to ensure they are in good condition and fit for use.

From the beginning of Elul and throughout the High Holiday season, we include the blessing "May you be inscribed and sealed for a good year" (Leshanah tovah tikateiv veteichateim) in letters and greetings to one another. Traditional greetings wish others a good inscription for the new year, and Selichot (penitential) prayers begin in Elul's final week.

The anthology includes four Rebbe-based articles: one on Elul's history as a spiritual refuge, one on its astrological sign and its parallel to the marriage between God and Israel, and two exploring Rabbi Schneur Zalman of Liadi's parable of the king in the field.

Dedicated in loving memory of Rabbi Akiva Wagner.
May his memory be a blessing.

# The 80-Minute Transformation

By Yaakov Abrams

My Story - with the - Rebbe



While I was enrolled as a graduate student at the University of Chicago – a time when I was just becoming religious – I faced a serious personal problem. Suffice it to say that it was an extremely difficult situation and I was in tremendous emotional pain, so I decided to write about it to the Rebbe. In my letter – which was about a dozen pages long – I detailed the entire background of the matter, its history, its issues, totally pouring out my heart.

In short order, I received a response, dated the 11th day of the Hebrew month of Sivan, 5744 or June 11, 1984:

The Torah of Life expects a Jew to do what is necessary in the natural order while placing complete trust in G-d for success. Thus, in matters of health, the Torah clearly instructs [one] to see a medical specialist and follow his instructions. At the same time, one must pray to G-d to send His blessings in this and all needs, as it is written "And G-d will bless you in all that you do."

The Rebbe gave me his blessing for "substantial improvement" in my situation and concluded by pointing out that we had just celebrated the holiday of Shavuot, when we commemorated the Giving of the Torah and its commandments at Mount Sinai. These commandments, he wrote, are channels through which we receive G-d's blessings both spiritually and materially.

In other words, the Rebbe was saying that, if I applied myself to keeping the Torah, I could expect to transform my life.

Truth be told, I was a bit disappointed by that response. I had been expecting some amazing blessing that would miraculously transform the situation without my input, so I went to mystics for guidance, which I followed until it became clear that doing so would lead to disaster.

In retrospect, I realize just how right the Rebbe had been – at that time in my life I needed to make my way within the confines of nature, while trusting in G-d and asking for His help. If I did that, things would ultimately work out for the best. A miraculous blessing was not the solution.

But then came a time in my life when a miraculous blessing was called for and the Rebbe readily gave it.

This happened in 1986, when my late wife Chanah became pregnant with our first child. It was an extremely difficult pregnancy and she was very ill, throwing up eight times a day. If she was awake, she was nauseous. She threw up everything that she took in – even water. She became so sick that there was no life to her.

The doctors put her on intravenous fluids to keep her hydrated, as her veins had nearly collapsed. By the third month of pregnancy, she had lost nearly 20 pounds and looked like she was at death's door.

Finally, the doctors decided that the whole situation was becoming dangerous for her as well as the baby, and they proposed implanting a catheter in order to supply total parenteral nutrition (TPN) and thus nourish her and the baby. If that didn't work, they said, an abortion would be required, because she would not make it through the pregnancy.

When we were told this, I called the Chabad House in San Diego where we were then living and spoke with Mrs. Chana Boas. Her advice was very forceful: "You must call the Rebbe! Promise me you will call the Rebbe!"

I called the Rebbe's office and spoke with his secretary, Rabbi Leibel Groner, telling him exactly what was going on, all the details of my wife's condition and that surgery was imminent – in fact, she was to report to the hospital four hours hence. He said that he would go to the Rebbe immediately to ask for a blessing.

At the time of that conversation, I was at work, and an hour and twenty minutes later (I remember looking at the clock), I decided to go home for lunch. I remember struggling with myself to call my wife to tell her that I was on my way home. It was so painful to listen to her voice of utter despair. Day in and day out, this person whom I really loved was suffering so much and seemingly losing her will to live. So, I hesitated whether to call her or not. But I did call and was astonished to hear a vibrant female voice answer the phone with "Hello!"

I couldn't believe it was my wife. She sounded so normal!

"Chanah, is that you?" I asked in shock.

"Yes," she answered.

"You sound so much better," I said.

"Yes," she confirmed. "I got up and went to the kitchen and made some breakfast, and I actually held it down."

"I'm coming home right away," I said.

I drove over the speed limit and was home in five minutes to find the woman who just that morning had no will to move, no will to live, acting normal. It was just amazing and, of course, we cancelled the surgery.

The next day we got a call from Rabbi Groner who said that the Rebbe had a message for us: "It's the month of Elul, and the King is in the field." By this he meant that, during the month just before Rosh Hashanah, G-d is most accessible.

The Rebbe cared enough to have his secretary call us back. How many thousands of people were calling the Rebbe every week? Yet he took the time not only to give us his blessing but also to send us this message: "The King is in the field."

It was an important and life-transforming message. The King really was in the field and heard our call for help. And I attribute that to the Rebbe's intervention.

A skeptic might say, "She had a rough first trimester and it happened to end within an hour and twenty minutes of when you called the Rebbe. It's just a coincidence." But to me it was miraculous. I know that many women have difficulty in the first trimester, but not to the extent my wife did. She was near death, and if not for her sudden recovery, she might not have made it.

But she did, and six months later – on the 24th day of the Hebrew month of Nissan, 1987 – she gave birth to our son Yonasan who now serves as a Chabad emissary in Temecula, California.

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*Mr. Jay B. (Yaakov) Abrams is a business appraiser and author of four books on business valuation who lives and works in Valley Village, California. He was interviewed in September of 2011.*

# Save Your Goldfish or Your Mother?

By Rabbi Aron Moss

Ask the Rabbi

## Question:

My teenage daughter came home from school shocked. Her maths teacher told the class that if she had to choose between saving her goldfish or her mother, she would save her goldfish. The students asked, “Is your mother that awful?” "Not at all," she replied. "We're just not very close, and I've had my goldfish for years. I'm very attached to it." So the students asked, what if you could only save us or your goldfish, which would you choose? And she said, without blinking an eye, my goldfish. What is wrong here?

## Response:

That is a fantastic teacher. She has taught in one lesson what others take years to give over. She has taught by example what happens when people lose a moral compass.

Her moral judgment is based on personal preference. She loves her cat. She loves her goldfish. She isn't close with her mother. The priorities are clear. I save who I love the most. My pets.

This worldview turns morality into a popularity contest. Whoever I love most wins. Right and wrong are replaced by likes and dislikes. What’s right for me may not be what’s right for you, as we all have different preferences. Maybe you love your mother more than you love your goldfish. That’s your business. And if I happen to prefer my mother over my goldfish, well, that’s up to me.

This is a dangerous path. Once morality is based on personal preference, anything can be justified. Your daughter’s class learnt that when imagining their teacher leaving them to die while she saves her goldfish.

We don’t think that way. Right and wrong are not subject to my tastes and fancies. Even if I love my goldfish, a human life is infinitely more valuable. A stranger I've never met takes precedence over my beloved pet. The value of a life is not measured by how I feel about it.

Every human being is created in G-d’s image and has infinite worth. This is not to devalue animals. We must treat them humanely. The Torah commands us to feed our animals before we feed ourselves, and to avoid causing needless harm to any living being. But when it comes to saving lives, humans come first.

Tell your daughter she was right to be shocked. Her instincts were spot on. That teacher was wrong. She should stick to teaching maths, because her morality doesn't add up.

## Living Moshiach

"G-d, your G-d, would not listen to Bilam, but ... transformed the curse into a blessing for you, because G-d, your G-d, loves you." (Ki Teitzei 23:6)

Bilam's prophecy deals with the ultimate downfall of the nations and Israel's victory over them (see Balak 24:17ff.).

Just as Bilam used his full prophetic power to bless Israel, so, in the future, the nations of the world will use their energy to help Israel. Thus it is written: "Kings will be your foster-fathers and their queens your nursing mothers" (Isaiah 49:23).

In this verse, therefore, there is an allusion to the change from golah (exile) to ge'ulah (redemption) – the transformation of the solemn days of fasting and mourning into days of "joy and gladness and cheerful festivals" (Zechariah 8:19).

## Mitzvah Minute

No, it's not a Jewish doorbell. It's a home security device called a mezuzah, and it's wired into the Ultimate Protection Agency. The software inside this gadget is a scroll with the words beginning, "Hear O Israel, the L-rd is our G-d; the L-rd is one." Those powerful words sum up the mandate of a Jew: to infuse the world with G-d's oneness. We place the mezuzah on our doorposts, and G-d's oneness surrounds us and protects us.

You'll need a mezuzah scroll—hand-written by a scribe on specially prepared parchment with a specific quill and ink, so buy from a reliable source—along with a protective case. Affix it to the right doorpost of every proper room (except the bathroom), angled in the top third of the doorpost, top pointing inward.

Before affixing, recite the blessing: "Blessed are you, L-rd our G-d, King of the universe, who has sanctified us with His commandments and commanded us to affix a mezuzah." Touch (and kiss) the mezuzah each time you enter or leave, and have it professionally checked at least twice every seven years to make sure no letters have cracked or faded.

The Lamplighter

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